Designing the Future We Want

Civic Skill: Long-Term Thinking | EYLF: Outcome 4 (Learning) & Outcome 5 (Communicating) | Duration: 25–30 minutes | Age: 4–6 years

LEARNING INTENTION

Children will begin to imagine a future version of their world, their family, their community, their planet, and to identify what matters most to them about it. This is the earliest form of civic imagination: picturing a future worth wanting, and naming what should carry forward into it.

SUCCESS CRITERIA

- I can imagine what my world might be like when I'm grown up.
- I can point to one thing I hope stays the same, and one thing I hope changes.
- I can show my idea in a way that makes sense to me — drawing, words, or an object.

MATERIALS

- A large 'Future Map' — butcher's paper with a simple line dividing 'Now' and 'Later'
- Small loose-part figures (people, homes, trees, animals) for children who prefer not to draw or speak
- Picture cards of lots of different items and themes
- Two icon cards: an anchor ('keep') and a seedling ('change')
- Picture book: 'The Curious Garden' by Peter Brown, or 'Once Upon Our Time' by Niki Daly
- Drawing materials and a camera for documentation

ACTIVITY STEPS

1. OPENING CIRCLE (4 min): Hold up the two icon cards. 'This anchor means something we want to keep. This seedling means something we want to grow into something new. Today we're going to imagine our world. What should we keep? What should change?'

2. BOOK READ-ALOUD (6 min): Read the chosen book. Pause: 'What do you notice about the world in this story? Does it change? What stays the same?'

3. THE FUTURE MAP (10 min): Children work at the mural individually or in pairs, adding one thing to the 'keep' side and one to the 'change' side — by placing an object, drawing, or dictating to the educator. Prompt: 'What matters to you? Why does that matter?'

4. SHARING CIRCLE (6 min): Children who wish to may show their addition: 'I want to keep ___ because ___' or 'I want ___ to change because ___.' An object placed without words is just as valid a contribution as a spoken one.

5. CLOSING (2 min): 'Everyone here just helped design a future. When we talk together about what matters most for a long time coming. Your ideas count, today, and later.'

EXTENSIONS

- Revisit the Future Map monthly, adding new 'keep' and 'change' items as children grow
- Pair with the existing 'Letter to Future Us' lesson as a two-part sequence

ASSESSMENT

- Anecdotal note: does the child distinguish 'keep' from 'change' meaningfully, or add items at random?
- Language note: does the child use future-oriented language ('when I'm grown up', 'later', 'always')?
- Documentation: photograph the Future Map with transcribed captions — this is the primary pilot artefact

EDUCATOR REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- Which children needed the object or drawing option rather than words — what did that reveal?
- Did any child's 'keep' or 'change' surprise you?
- How did the 'what matters most' framing need to be translated for this age group? What worked, and what didn't?

EYLF LINKS

This lesson directly supports EYLF Outcome 4 (Learning) & Outcome 5 (Communicating), and previews the National Conversation Development Lab's Level 1 — Civic Imagination inquiry ("What matters most?"). Educators should record observations using anecdotal notes, photographs, or learning stories.